International cricketers often take a lot of stick from the press and public if they complain that they're tired and need a break. The common perception is that we're a bunch of overpaid prima donnas who don't appreciate how lucky we are to be making a living out of playing sport. But people don't appreciate that when we say we are tired, we are referring not to physical fatigue, but being knackered mentally. International cricket is played at a high intensity, the stakes are high, and the pressures and expectations are huge. You can really take strain with that. I don't care who you are or how big you reckon your balls are – do this for a living and you'll appreciate what I mean.

But, back to my initial point: because older guys like Hayden and Gilchrist have now retired from the international scene, and they're both in top shape, they come into tournaments like the IPL nice and fresh. And the pressure they feel is a world apart from what they experienced when playing for their country. They just go out there and have a blast, klapping the ball all over the show.

I'm looking forward to being in their position, but before I bow out of international cricket completely, I still want one more bash at the World Cup. Ja, a World Cup medal is the one thing I want very badly. And I'm talking proper 50-over ODI cricket here, not T20. As mentioned in the previous chapter, I have re-signed my UCB contract until April 2011, and Corrie van Zyl has made it clear to me that I am in their plans for the 2011 World Cup. The teams I have played for in the past have come so close – particularly in 1999 – and I'd love to be able to erase the painful memories with a shiny gold medal and the title of world champions.

I'm still fit and trim, and my reflexes are spot-on. Look, I might be a yard slower than I was at 20, but I still put myself about. I have never *not* put my body on the line in practices, and I still flipping dive around like an idiot on the square. It's a part of me; it's just who I am.

Ja, so touch wood, I haven't had any major injuries since I did my knee all those years ago. A lot of it has got to do with maintaining myself in the gym. I'm also lucky that I have a good metabolism – I eat a lot of rubbish, and the booze doesn't help, but if I put in the hard yards on the treadmill, I work it all off.

I know that, at 36, you are supposed to be getting a little long in the tooth for professional sports, but, honestly, I don't feel it physically. There's nothing in my physical attributes to say that I am 36, and no one can tell me